major Naxal-affected areas?

This was the second prong. To reduce the security vacuum in most Naxal-affected districts, the CAPF, in collaboration with the state police, set up more camps called Forward Operating Bases (FOB) that worked systematically to clear the area of Naxals. In the past five years, 302 new camps have been set up. Strategically, as we cleared areas of Naxals, we handed them over to the police so that FOBs could move ahead to clear the remaining security vacuum areas. To do that, we expanded the Fortified Police Station programme from 2014 onwards by constructing 612 such stations as compared to the 66 earlier. In these stations, we ensured adequate armed personnel with communication facilities to provide security to the locals in the areas cleared of Naxals.

Q. What about employing modern technology, including for surveillance?

We trained our forces battling Naxals to be new age friendly and integrated with modern technologies. We modernised intelligence-gathering with infusion of technology, including drones, satellite imaging and AI. This enabled our forces to map Naxal movement patterns. Earlier, most casualties on our forces' side were because of the Naxals setting up ambushes. So, in an engagement with them, the forces would pursue them and find themselves trapped from all sides. Now, with the help of drones, they can see where the Naxals are hiding and take evasive action. Also, through techniques like location-tracking, mobile phone activities, scientific call logs and social media analysis, we are able to keep a close watch on Naxal movement. To improve the morale of our security personnel, we have deployed helicopters to facilitate both operations and medical evacuation. In addition, we have recruited over 1,143 people from the affected districts to serve in the police stations.

Q. How many Naxals have surrendered and how has it been useful?

Around 7,500 Naxals have surrendered in the past 10 years, mainly due to the increase in our operations. They, in turn, play a role in future surrenders. Many of these surrendered Naxals have joined the state police, including the district reserve guards. They know the terrain of the region and Naxal tactics well and have become a force multiplier for us. The utilisation of the surrendered Naxals is an example of the phenomenal use of manpower in the larger plan and should be analysed and studied as a model.

Q. How successful have you been in eliminating the top echelons of the Naxal leadership?

Our approach to the Politburo and Central Committee members of the Naxals is to trace, target and neutralise them. We have in the past five years eliminated 15 such Naxalite leaders. Apart from these, in just the last year, we have killed one zonal committee member, five sub zonal committee members, two state committee members, 31 divisional committee members and 59 area committee members. Targeting their leadership has severely impacted the Naxal movement. However, our primary efforts involve persuading the Naxals to renounce violence and join the mainstream. Elimination is an option we exercise only to protect the lives of innocent tribal people from gun-toting hardened criminals who instead of surrendering continue to be a serious threat to civilians.



OUTREACH CENTRAL Amit Shah meets locals at Naxal-affected Potakpalli village in Sukma, March 2023

> "WITH A **TRACE, TARGET AND NEUTRALISE APPROACH, WE ELIMINATED 15 MEMBERS** OF THE CENTRAL COMMITTEE AND POLITBURO IN 5 YEARS, SEVERELY IMPACTING THE MOVEMENT"

Q. What has been done to stem Naxal funding and flow of arms?

The third prong of the Modi government's plan was to put a squeeze on Naxal funds and their arms supply. Taking illegal levies from tendu patta-plucking and *ugaai* (extortion) from road contractors was the main source of their funding. One of the things we did was to introduce online payment systems which helped curb the outflow of money to them. To prevent contractors from paying extortion money to the Naxalites, we instilled a sense of security in them. Then, we created a separate vertical in the National Investigation Agency that seized Naxal assets of more than Rs 40 crore. The Enforcement Directorate is also closely monitoring their money-laundering activities and has seized Rs 12 crore of their assets. We have